

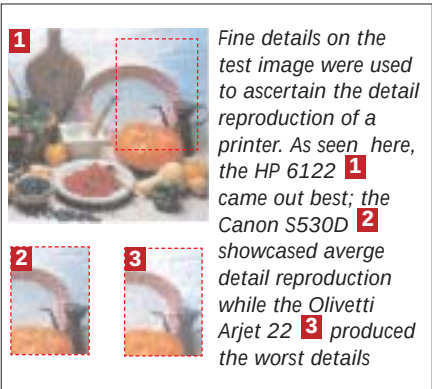
also noted. This is done, considering that large-sized image files are most likely to form the bulk of the tasks, and printers with lesser memory will cause a bottleneck. All these features weighed higher than speed while calculating the STTI.

To further narrow down on the overall score, we factored the performance score with the price in such a way that, any printer that cost between Rs 10,000 to Rs 20,000, and scored above 76 STTI, would be considered for this application area.

The best printers for professional printing

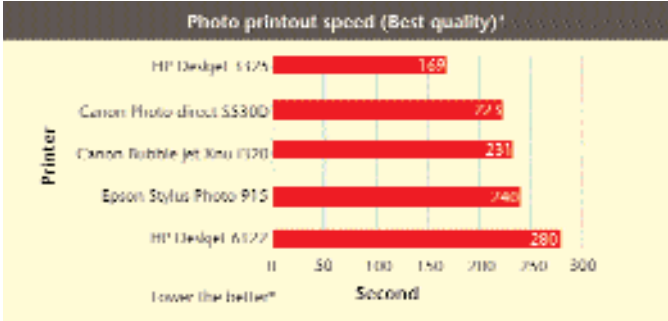
With the aforementioned considerations, all the printers were assessed, based on the quality of output, and this got us the test analysis for the best possible professional printing solution.

When it came to quality, nothing could beat the HP 6122—this printer reproduced colour and the finer details from the test



picture with every bit of accuracy. For example, the combination document contains a group of different elements, such as wood, fruits, glass articles, etc; the wall has many bumps—none of the printers could reproduce these bumps and the other features on

the wall as accurately as the HP 6122. Further, even the details on the fruits—such as the light reflection—were excellent. This was also one of the printers that could reproduce all the seven colour bars perfectly. And, it wasn't too slow either; while the fastest printer took around 14 seconds to print the text file, the HP 6122 finished in about 17 seconds. Similarly, the time required for printing the image file is also less than the average time taken by other printers. Coming to the features, this print-



er comes with a mammoth 8 MB memory buffer, supports dual-side printing and has a paper-tray that can store up to 100 papers. The printer scored 76 on the STTI score.

Canon was not to be left behind in the quality front, and came very close to dethroning the HP 6122, but lost on the price front. Canon S503D is loaded with features, and hosts support for all the latest possible technologies. It performed equally well throughout the test and displayed the same vigour as the HP 6122. But, its crucial contending aspect was the quality of output. Only in certain areas did it lag—the bumps on the wall and the light reflection on the fruits were missing.

The S503D does not compromise speed for quality's sake. It took only 14 seconds to print the text file, and similar results were found for the combination-document (88 seconds) and the image file printing where it was amongst the best (223 seconds).

The printer is equipped with USB 2.0 interface, supports printing directly from a digital camera and also comes with an LCD screen. The screen indicates the possible settings of a digicam, to enable direct printing. The S503D came one step behind the HP 6122 by posting 75 on the STTI.

Another printer that stands out from the crowd is the Epson Photo 915. Designed along the same lines as the Canon S503D, it too features direct printing from a camera, an LCD screen to program the settings and comes with a four-in-one memory stick adapter. Its performance was comparable to its nearest competitors, but it lost on the details and colour reproduction. Also, all the printers from Epson showed a high degree of paper dependency—i.e. the quality of the output was excellent on the manufacturer recommended print media, but suffered when printed on any other medium. Overall this printer could only amass 72 on the STTI scale.



Refill, Replace, Recycle?



Inkjet printers have a very high maintenance cost, primarily because of the cost of cartridge replacements and the expenses incurred as a result of using bad quality cartridges.

Users have an option of either using original cartridges or refilling them. Typically, users prefer the latter route as it is more cost-effective. Refill kits, that contain all the tools required for the task, are also available. The problem with them is that the ink provided along cannot be used with all the cartridges: different cartridges have their own standards (every printer model needs an ink of a certain viscosity, texture, shade, mixture) and hence a single kit cannot provide an all-encompassing solution.

One can also opt for compatible or replacement cartridges, manufactured by third parties or Original Equipment Manufacturers (OEMs). These are reliable as they are manufactured keeping in mind the model of the printer. Another variety of cartridges extensively used these days are the recycled or re-manufactured ones. These are professionally recycled to guarantee high quality and good performance.